



PAW & POCKET PRESENTS

The Dog Cost Cheat Sheet

*What every dog really costs — the honest 2026 numbers,
before you fall for the puppy photos.*

6 breeds priced

The 5 hidden costs

Is insurance worth it?

Money-saving tips

SECTION 1

What six popular breeds really cost

Breeder puppy price, typical yearly cost, and the whole-life total — plus the one health cost that defines each breed.

BREED	PUPPY	PER YEAR	LIFETIME	LIVES	INSURE/MO
Labrador WATCH FOR Hip & elbow joints, and a big appetite that piles on weight.	\$800–\$2,500	\$1,700–\$2,900	\$27k–\$35k	10–13 yrs	\$35–\$65
German Shepherd WATCH FOR Hip/elbow dysplasia, bloat, and degenerative myelopathy.	\$800–\$2,500	\$1,500–\$3,000	\$25k–\$40k	9–13 yrs	\$40–\$75
Golden Retriever WATCH FOR Cancer — ~60% lifetime risk; chemo runs \$7k–\$12k.	\$1,000–\$3,500	\$2,000–\$3,500	\$20k–\$45k	10–12 yrs	\$35–\$70
French Bulldog WATCH FOR Breathing (BOAS) surgery \$2k–\$5k; skin & spine issues.	\$2,000–\$6,500	\$2,000–\$4,000	\$20k–\$40k	10–12 yrs	\$40–\$80
English Bulldog WATCH FOR Airway + skin, highest hip-dysplasia rate, shortest life.	\$1,500–\$4,500	\$2,000–\$4,000	\$22k–\$42k	8–10 yrs	\$70–\$100
Cavalier K.C. Spaniel WATCH FOR Heart disease (MVD) — near-certain with age.	\$1,500–\$3,500	\$1,200–\$2,200+	\$15k–\$38k	9–14 yrs	\$35–\$120

Well-researched 2026 planning estimates, not quotes.

SECTION 2

The 5 hidden costs nobody budgets for

The puppy price is the part everyone plans for. These are the parts that blindside people.

- 1 The day-one spike** — Crate, bed, bowls, neutering, first vaccines and vet checks land all at once — budget \$500–\$1,200 before your dog has settled in.
- 2 Dental care** — Cleanings and extractions add up, and skipping them leads to infections that cost far more later.
- 3 The emergency visit** — A single after-hours emergency can run \$1,000–\$5,000 in one night.
- 4 Breed health conditions** — Breed-specific surgery (airway, hips, heart, cancer) can be \$2,000–\$12,000+, and some breeds almost expect it.
- 5 Life admin** — Boarding, dog-walking, replacing chewed beds and leads, pet deposits on rent — the quiet drip that never shows up in the puppy price.

Is insurance worth it? A 60-second checklist

- ✓ Enrol while your dog is young and healthy — pre-existing conditions are never covered.
- ✓ High-risk breed (Frenchie, Bulldog, Golden, Cavalier, Shepherd)? The maths leans toward yes.
- ✓ Couldn't comfortably absorb a surprise \$5,000 bill from savings? Insurance earns its place.
- ✓ Check the policy doesn't exclude the breed's signature condition (airway, hips, heart).
- ✓ Compare the three numbers that matter: annual limit, deductible, reimbursement %.

5 ways to spend less (without feeding worse)

- Buy larger bags and use subscribe-and-save — an easy 5–15% off food you'd buy anyway.
- Don't pay for marketing words — "grain-free", "ancestral", "artisan" rarely matter for a healthy dog.
- Keep them lean. Obesity quietly worsens (and pays for) almost every other problem.
- Insure early to lock in lower premiums before any condition appears.
- Adopt or rescue — often saves \$1,000+ and includes vaccinations and neutering.



Want your dog's exact number?

These are ranges. Our free calculator gives you a personalised lifetime figure — pick your size, food, and whether you'd insure, and watch the total update. And for the full, honest breakdown on any breed, the breed guides go deep.

Start free → pawandpocket.com